



BEFORE

After Atlanta's fall General John Bell Hood embarked on an invasion of Union-held Tennessee, but Union generals George H. Thomas and John M. Schofield were waiting.

THE ROAD TO FRANKLIN

Hood hoped he might cut Union supply lines or maybe **join General Lee at Petersburg** (see [The Siege of Petersburg](#)), but General Thomas, in the city of Nashville with 40,000 men, lay in his path. General Schofield and his army of 30,000 were near Pulaski. Hood hoped to defeat them before they could join Thomas, setting a trap for them on November 29, some 15 miles (24km) south of Franklin.

On the afternoon of November 30, 1864 General Hood was still angry that the night before, through a series of blunders, his Army of Tennessee had somehow allowed 30,000 Union troops to slip past it. The Federals had dug in near the town of Franklin, Tennessee, which Hood's commanders could see 2 miles (3.2km) away from their temporary headquarters on the hilltop.

Although most of Hood's artillery and an infantry corps had still not arrived, the impetuous general had decided to attack the positions at Franklin anyway; his commanders were filled with foreboding. At 4 p.m., 18 brigades—nearly 20,000 men—moved out, lines dressed, flags flying, drums beating, and bands playing. Before them stretched those 2 miles (3.2km) of open, undulating fields browned by recent frosts. Rabbits bounded away as the tramping feet of this last great Confederate charge of the war approached.

Southern slaughter

General John Schofield's Union men watched spellbound as the Rebels approached. Crouched behind strong fieldworks fronted by felled trees, they shouldered impressive firepower; and massed artillery, some of it positioned to fire into the attacking columns from the flanks, backed them up. When the onslaught was within a hundred paces of the main line every Union trigger was squeezed. With a deafening roar a deadly hail of shot, shell, and canister tore through the Confederate ranks, shredding all formation and turning the regiments into blood-spattered mobs. Many troops, trapped in the tangle of felled trees, were caught in a murderous crossfire of